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FRIDAY
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CRICKET MEETS ROYALTY

■ Britain's King Charles III meets members of the Pakistan cricket team during an audience at Clarence House in London, on Wednesday, ahead of the third and final Test between Pakistan and England at Edgbaston, Birmingham, from September 9. Pakistan skipper Babar Azam also presented a bat to King Charles which had the signatures of all the players. The British monarch thanked the Pakistan team for the gesture before posing with them for a photo.

SEE ALSO P15

'A Dubai Invite' closes after 90,000 applications

DUBAI
BY ZAINAB HUSAIN
Features Writer

Dubai's 'A Dubai Invite' programme has closed to new registrations after receiving more than 90,000 applications from residents, with more than 30,000 benefit packages already distributed since the initiative launched in July.

Although new registrations have now closed, benefits will continue to be issued to residents who successfully registered visitors before the final allocation was reached.

Eligible visitors who have already been registered can still arrive in Dubai until October 31, 2026, with benefits issued within 72 hours of their guests' arrival.

The benefits will remain valid at participating venues until December 31, 2026.

Exclusive benefits

'A Dubai Invite' was the result of almost a year of collaboration between stakeholders across Dubai's public and private sectors.

Participating partners offered exclusive benefits covering attractions, dining, hotels and lifestyle experiences, giving successful applicants opportunities to share different aspects of Dubai with visiting friends and relatives.

MOHAMED, TRUMP DISCUSS MIDEAST DEVELOPMENTS

Iranian attack on Kuwait draws condemnation

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

UAE President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan and US President Donald Trump discussed developments in the Middle East and efforts to address them during a phone call as renewed US-Iran hostilities sent tensions surging across the region.

The two leaders also discussed cooperation between the UAE and the United States and ways to further strengthen ties in support of their mutual interests.

The call came amid a fresh escalation between Washington and Tehran, with Iran this week launching missiles and drones at US military bases across the Middle East following renewed American strikes on Iranian targets.

UAE's solidarity with Kuwait

The UAE yesterday strongly condemned an Iranian missile and drone attack targeting Kuwait, calling it a "flagrant violation" of the Gulf state's sovereignty and a threat to its security and stability.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs affirmed the UAE's full solidarity with Kuwait and its support for all measures aimed at safeguarding the country's security and stability.

Kuwait also condemned the overnight attack, describing it

● **US forces struck Iranian air-defence and radar systems, maritime assets, communications sites and facilities associated with mine-laying operations.**

as a "direct threat" to its security and the safety of its citizens and residents, as well as a grave breach of international law.

Iran said it had targeted US bases and forces in Kuwait and elsewhere in the region during its latest retaliation.

The Arab League warned that the Iranian escalation posed a direct threat to regional security and risked widening the conflict. It condemned renewed attacks on Arab countries and called for an immediate halt to aggression, maximum restraint and a return to political negotiations.

Trump: Strikes won't last 'too long'

Trump, meanwhile, said the latest US military strikes against Iran would not continue "too long", while warning that Washington remained ready to attack again. "We hit them very hard last night," Trump told US media. "We took out all of the new equipment that they tried to build along the Strait of Hor-

muz." US forces struck Iranian air-defence and radar systems, maritime assets, communications sites and facilities associated with mine-laying operations.

Iranian security chief Mohsen Rezaei warned that Tehran had adopted a "new strategy" in the war that he said would "shatter" America's foundations.

The latest exchanges have intensified concerns over shipping and oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz, which remains at the heart of the six-month conflict.

Diplomatic pressure grows

At the same time, diplomatic pressure for de-escalation is growing. Egypt and China called for reduced tensions and greater dialogue following talks during Chinese President Xi Jinping's visit to Egypt.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio also warned that countries helping Iran evade American sanctions could face penalties, while rejecting suggestions that India and Iran were preparing a trade agreement.

The renewed confrontation comes as Washington combines military strikes around Hormuz with pressure on Iranian oil exports and tougher economic sanctions, while Tehran continues to demonstrate its ability to retaliate against US interests across the region.

— With inputs from AFP
SEE ALSO P6

UAE non-oil growth fastest since 2024

New orders surged and cost pressures eased; employment fell for a second month

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

55.3

UAE Purchasing Managers' Index in August, up from 52.7 in July

UAE businesses saw their strongest improvement in operating conditions since December 2024 in August, helped by a surge in customer demand, stronger exports and fewer supply disruptions, although companies remained cautious about adding staff.

The S&P Global UAE Purchasing Managers' Index rose to 55.3 in August from 52.7 in July, signalling a second consecutive month of accelerating growth across the non-oil private sector.

New business increased at the joint-fastest pace in more than two years, while output growth reached a six-month high, pointing to a stronger third quarter for companies operating across the non-oil economy.

More customer activity

Companies reported an improvement in customer activity alongside a steady, though incomplete, easing of economic caution linked to the Middle East conflict. Export orders also expanded for a second consecutive month following declines throughout the second quarter.

Stronger sales, however, did not translate into increased hiring during August, with employment declining for the sec-

ond time in three months. New orders grew quickly enough to leave some companies unable to expand their operations at the same pace, resulting in a rapid increase in unfinished work. Firms also remained hesitant to take on additional staff because of uncertainty surrounding the regional conflict and its wider economic impact.

Companies stepped up purchasing activity and built inventories at the fastest rate in nearly three years, a marked change from the muted stock accumulation recorded in recent months.

More businesses also turned to local suppliers, helping reduce sourcing problems and improve delivery times.

Greater trade flows and faster deliveries from nearby vendors contributed to an easing in input cost inflation to its lowest level since February.

Prices charged by UAE non-oil businesses increased modestly in August, recording their fastest rise in four months.

Business confidence also strengthened, reaching its highest level since April, supported by improving sales, expectations surrounding construction projects and hopes that regional tensions would ease.

IN FOCUS



TOXIC HAZE CLOUDS SOUTHEAST ASIA

Schools shut and illnesses rise as smoke from widespread forest and land fires in Indonesia drifts across borders | P8-9

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